

Women.” They did so under a statue of Tlazolteotl, who was the goddess of vice and disease but also of purification.

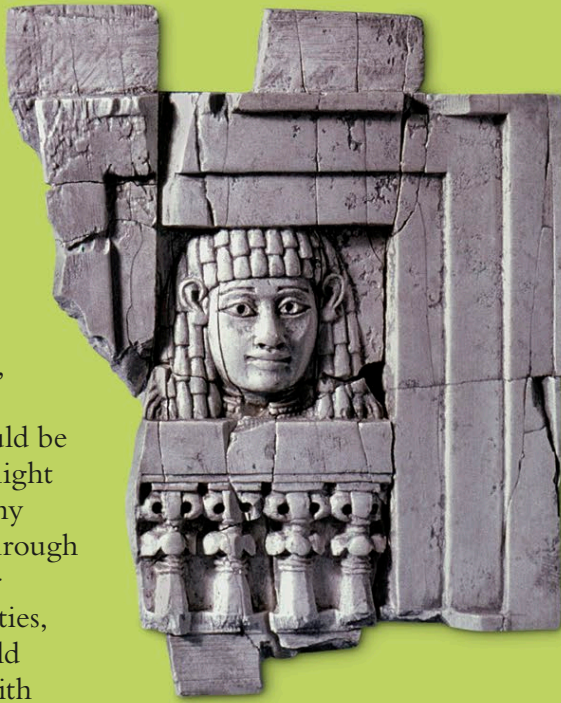
Non-sacred prostitution was also common. As well as purely sexual encounters, there were several types of companionship women could be employed in. Courtesans might act as companions to wealthy men, and entertain them through dancing, reciting poetry, or conversation; in some societies, although these women could engage in sexual activity with patrons, such services were not always assumed.

Prostitution and the Law

Modern societies have taken a range of approaches to prostitution legislation—from outright bans to partial criminalization to full legalization and government regulation, as in Amsterdam, where a prostitution ban was lifted in 1811. Those working in the “red-light” (pleasure) district were made to have health checks as the Dutch government regulated the industry. Early feminists such as Josephine Butler fought against these compulsory checks, seeing them as violations of women’s bodies.

In the late 20th century, legislation moved toward protecting women, rather than simply banning solicitation. In 1978, activist Carol Leigh used the term “sex work” to emphasize that, as workers, prostitutes deserve better pay, working conditions, and health care, and in the 20th century, the Scandinavian countries introduced the “Nordic Model,” which made it illegal to buy sex but not to sell it.

Since the early 20th century, laws have distinguished between prostitution and sex trafficking, in which women are coerced into sex work. The League of Nations sought to address trafficking in 1921, and it is now illegal under international law, whereas legislation against prostitution is much more varied.



▲ Ancient priestess

This Assyrian ivory carving, from the 8th century BCE, shows a sacred prostitute—a priestess of Inanna (see pp. 18-19), who would have ritual sex with male visitors to the temple to release divine energy.



PROFILES

WORKERS AND REFORMERS

Su Xiaoxiao (d. 501 CE), also known as Su Xiaojun and “Little Su,” was a courtesan and poet during the Southern Qi Dynasty in ancient China. There are almost no historical records of her life, but some accounts say she was forced into prostitution at fifteen to help her family.

Jeanne Bécu, Comtesse Du Barry

(1743-1793) was the *Maîtresse-en-titre*, or chief mistress, of King Louis XV of France. When she was 20, Bécu’s great beauty caught the eye of pimp Jean-Baptiste Du Barry, who facilitated her career as a courtesan to aristocratic men before she caught the eye of the king. She was beheaded during the French Revolution.

Josephine Butler (1828-1906) was a 19th-century English feminist and social reformer. In 1869 she began campaigning to repeal the Contagious Diseases Act, which forced prostitutes to submit to medical exams. The Act was finally repealed in 1886. Butler fought for similar reforms in other parts of Europe through her organization the International Abolitionist Federation.

Tilly Devine (1900-1970) engaged in prostitution as a young woman before moving to Australia with her husband and becoming a prominent crime boss and madam. She acquired dozens of criminal convictions for prostitution and spent time in prison for slashing a man in a barbershop with a razor. Devine was called the “Worst Woman in Sydney” and “The Queen of the Night” in the press. She ran her brothel in Sydney until 1968.

Margo St. James (b. 1937) is the founder of COYOTE (Call Off Your Old Tired Ethics), an organization that calls for the decriminalization of sex work. In 1999, COYOTE helped to create the St. James Infirmary Clinic, a free health and safety clinic run by and for sex workers in San Francisco. St. James is herself a former sex worker.

Somaly Mam (b. 1970) is a Cambodian anti-trafficking activist who focuses on sex trafficking. In 1996, Mam founded the organization *Agir pour les Femmes en Situation Précaire* (Acting for Women in Distressing Situations,) which rescues and rehabilitates women and children trafficked in Cambodia, Laos, and Vietnam.